a FlexLifeFi K-12 program

How to Run This Year

Routines, pacing, FAQ, and the calibration of Cash's voice.

Grade 12 year theme — Launch-Ready Entrepreneurship.
The 9-12 band is built for the adults who will scrutinize: parents, teachers, administrators.

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GRADE 12 · TEACHER GUIDE

How to Run This

Founder-defensible plans built on evidence, not enthusiasm.

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For the teacher of the program's capstone year. This guide assumes you've taught some or all of Grades 9-11, or have read the Grade 7 canonical pattern and the Grade 11 Showcase. If you haven't, start there. Grade 12 isn't a new skill set — it's the integration year of skills built since middle school. Your job in Grade 12 is to enforce the synthesis, hold the line on evidence, and run the Capstone Defense like the public, structured assessment it is.

WITH CASH - 9-12 VOICE

"Which people, and how do you know?"

What's different about Grade 12

> "I don't know either. That's why we test."
>
> - CASH, GRADE 12

Three things make this year structurally distinct from the rest of the program.

One. The Capstone is the year. It's not a final project bolted to the end. Every artifact across all four units feeds the same final defense. The student's portfolio in June is the sum of work done in September, December, February, and April. Treat each unit's anchor artifact as a stepping stone, not a one-off.

Two. The year requires an exit decision. Each student finishes with a written, defended Launch-or-Learn statement: launch (continue past graduation), pivot (change the model and continue), or shelve (stop, with reasons). All three are honored equally. The Decision Quality criterion on the rubric explicitly rewards a well-defended shelve over a poorly defended launch. If your school culture isn't ready for that, prepare administrators and families in writing during Unit 1.

Three. The Defense itself is a 30-minute structured panel session. Format mirrors a thesis defense, an investor meeting, and a job interview at once. It's the most adult assessment in the K-12 program. Schedule it in Weeks 35-36; brief panelists in advance; rehearse with students starting Week 30.

Year rhythm and weekly routines

The year operates on a 36-week clock with 2-4 instructional periods per week. The most common implementation is one 90-minute block plus one 50-minute follow-up.

Friday is journal day. Protect 10 minutes at the end of the Friday class for the Capstone Journal. Write while they write. The journal is the most-skipped artifact and the most predictive of Defense quality.

Mondays open with a "which people, and how do you know?" check. Pick one student's claim from the previous week and lift it for class examination. Three minutes max. The point is to keep the question reflexive.

Pivot windows are real. In Weeks 9, 18, and 27, formally open a pivot window. Students with evidence that points to a different venture may switch. Most won't. The point is the option, and the discipline of considering it.

Variance reports start Week 31. Once the 90-day plan is built, students report variance every Friday for four weeks (Weeks 31-34). Read every report personally for the first three weeks; peer review can take over by Week 34.

The Defense — what to do, week by week

Week	Move
30	First mock Defense in pairs. 5-min presentation each. Rubric in hand. Goal: surface what's missing.
31	Second mock with a different partner. Add a panel of 3 (other students). Q&A for 5 min.
32	Third mock with at least one outside adult panelist (a colleague from another department, not a parent).
33	Final dry run. Full 30-minute format with mixed panel.
34	Slide finalization. Artifact filing. Last variance report.
35-36	Defense Days. Schedule 30 minutes per student. Each Defense is graded on the spot by the panel. Written feedback to student within 5 school days.

The mocks aren't optional. A student who hasn't done at least three mocks before Defense Day is being set up to fail. Build them into the calendar.

Panel composition

3-5 panelists per Defense. Composition guidance:

- The classroom teacher (you).
- One additional teacher from another department (math, English, social studies, art — diverse perspectives are useful).
- Optional: a school administrator.
- **At least one outside professional.** Local entrepreneurs, small-business owners, nonprofit leaders, accountants, or college admissions professionals all work. The outside panelist matters: it makes the Defense feel like the real-adult assessment it is.
- For students with IEPs that require it: a known support adult.

Panel briefing

Brief panelists in writing before Defense Day. Key rules:

- No advice on family money. Period.
- No "when I was your age" comparisons.
- Questions probe evidence, financial logic, and decision quality — not personality, charisma, or business idea preference.
- A great shelve is full credit. Panelists who don't like that should not panel.
- If a student folds in Q&A, panelists may pose a softer question to allow recovery — but the panel still grades honestly on Q&A handling.

A 1-page panelist briefing is in the program assets.

AN INTERLUDE · GRADE 12

"Which people, and how do you know?"

the program's spine question.

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Grading philosophy

> **"Which people, and how do you know?"**
>
> - CASH, GRADE 12

Grade 12 uses analytic scoring, not holistic — every Capstone artifact is scored against the appropriate rubric from the Rubric Bank, criterion by criterion. The Defense itself uses a 7-criterion rubric: 6 from the Pitch Presentation Rubric (full 9-12 version) plus a Decision Quality criterion unique to Grade 12.

The Decision Quality criterion is non-negotiable. Score it cleanly:

- **4.** Decision matches the evidence. Reasoning is specific and tested under panel pressure. Alternatives explicitly considered.
- **3.** Decision is plausible given the evidence. Some reasoning shaky under pressure but recoverable.
- **2.** Decision wobbles under questioning. Evidence supports a different decision.
- **1.** Decision contradicts the evidence. Reasoning collapses under questioning.

A student with strong delivery and weak Decision Quality cannot earn a 4 overall. The rubric protects against the smooth-talker trap, which is the failure mode most likely to undermine the program's credibility with future cohorts.

Common pitfalls (and how to handle them)

Pitfall 1: The student with no idea on Day 1

A few students will arrive in September having never seriously considered what venture they'd run. Don't push them to commit too fast — but don't let them coast for six weeks either. By Week 4 (the premortem lesson), they need a Door #1 specific enough to attack. Coach question: "What do people ask you to help them with? What irritates you that nobody fixes?"

Pitfall 2: The student with a real existing venture

Some students arrive with a venture they've been running since Grade 9. Honor it. The Capstone artifacts still apply. The financial pack often shocks them — they've been operating

without one. The 5-of-5 conversations may need to be with new customer segments to stay rigorous.

Pitfall 3: The student who treats the journal as homework

The journal is the load-bearing artifact for the PSIG strand. A student with 10 perfunctory entries fails the Reflection Writing Rubric. Coach early: read 3 student journals in Week 4 and have a private conversation with the weakest. Public reading of strong entries (with permission) is high-leverage.

Pitfall 4: The student who under-reports variance

Hiding a missed week is the most expensive mistake a Capstone student makes. The point of variance isn't to be green; it's to surface what was missed. Coach: "Honest doesn't mean pessimistic. Honest means accurate. The point is the lesson, not the color."

Pitfall 5: The student aiming for a forced launch

Some students will arrive at Week 30 with thin evidence and an emotional commitment to launching anyway. The rubric protects you here. Score Decision Quality honestly. The post-Defense conversation is real coaching: "Your evidence supports a pivot. Here's what would have to change in 4 weeks to support a launch. The honest call now is pivot." They will hear it more easily from the rubric than from you.

Pitfall 6: The student with genuine performance anxiety

A small number of students will experience real anxiety about a 30-minute panel defense. Build accommodations early. Three mocks reduce anxiety more than any pep talk. For students whose IEP or documented need calls for it, allow a recorded-then-reviewed format with written Q&A. The Decision Quality criterion can still be assessed in writing.

FAQ

Q: What if a student's venture is technically "illegal" — selling food without a permit, for example?

The Compliance Checklist exists precisely to surface this. A student who realizes their venture would need a permit and chooses not to pursue it (or pursues the permit) has done good work. Score the thinking, not the legal status of the venture. If a student is actually selling unsafe food to classmates as part of their Capstone, intervene immediately and refer to school administration.

Q: How real does "real customer" have to be for the 5-of-5?

A real adult who is not a Cash to Company classmate. Teachers count. School staff count. Family friends count. A parent's coworker counts. Random social-media respondents to a survey do not count. The point is a structured conversation with a person who could conceivably be a customer, not a click on a poll.

Q: What if a student wants to launch a venture I think is a bad idea?

Score on the rubric. A bad idea defended on weak evidence scores low on Decision Quality. A bad idea defended on real evidence with clear-eyed acknowledgment of risk scores higher. Your job is not to gatekeep ideas; it's to enforce evidence and decision discipline. A confident student launching a "bad" idea with eyes open is doing what the program asked.

Q: How do I handle a student whose family discourages the venture?

Don't probe family details. The student decides what to do post-graduation; the Defense grades the thinking, not the launch. Be ready for: "My family wants me to focus on college and not pursue this." The honest answer is shelve, defended on evidence and personal context. Score it the same as any clean shelve.

Q: Outside panelists are hard to recruit. Help.

Three sources work: (1) parents of younger students in the program, (2) local Small Business Development Centers, and (3) college admissions or alumni offices in your network. Each panelist commits to one 30-minute slot. Many will say yes when asked specifically and given the briefing.

Q: A student earns a 1 on Decision Quality. Are they "failing the program"?

A 1 means the decision contradicts the evidence. That's a real teaching moment, not a failure of the student's whole year. The other six rubric criteria still score independently. A student can earn a passing overall grade with a 1 on Decision Quality if other criteria are strong — but the post-Defense feedback letter must name the gap clearly. Some students will absorb the lesson and remember it for years.

AN INTERLUDE · GRADE 12

"Most adults skip t step. You won't."

the band's working assumption.

2

Calibrating with co-teachers

> **“Some of this is hard because the world's hard. The skill is knowing what's in your hands.”**
>
> - CASH, GRADE 12

If you teach Grade 12 with another teacher (or hand off mid-year), calibrate scoring before grading begins. Pull two anchor Defenses from the prior year's recordings (or use the program's calibration set). Score each independently. Discuss any criterion where you score more than 1 point apart. The most common calibration drift is on Decision Quality (some teachers favor the launch; others over-favor the safe shelve). Surface that bias in the calibration session.

For the Reflection Writing and Customer Research rubrics, anchor papers from the program assets are pre-scored. Re-score 2 of them at the start of each unit.

When the year is hard

The hardest moment of Grade 12 is rarely Defense Day. It's the week in February when a student you like is staring at thin evidence and dreading the call. Be ready for that moment. Tell them: the honest decision is the right decision. A great shelve is full credit. The point was the thinking, not the launch. Mean it. They'll know.

Some Defenses will move you. Students will, on Defense Day, name something about themselves they didn't know in September. They will, on rare occasions, say something so clean about who they are and what they're for that the room goes still. Receive those moments without gushing. Cash never says "amazing." The program's posture is okay, good — show me the evidence. The student will remember which adult held the line on substance.

You're the last classroom teacher these students will have in the program. Many will graduate next month. Some will start ventures. Most won't, this year. All of them will, somewhere in the next decade, encounter a decision that involves money under uncertainty — and they will hear which people, and how do you know? in the back of their head. That's the program. That's the bet. That's the year.

Senior expert upgrade pack — Differentiation deep moves (Grade 12)

Advanced learners — three named extensions (specific, not just "more")

1. **The "I am declining to launch" defense.** A student who's leaning shelve writes a full defense for shelving. Surfaces honesty; shelving is a valid path the curriculum endorses but advanced students often resist.
2. **Multi-state compliance research.** Advanced students compare compliance requirements (sales tax, registration, age limits) across 3 states. Real founders deal with this; teen founders going online deal with it on Day 1.
3. **The investor-readiness gap memo.** Honest 1-page memo: "I am [X] gaps short of being investor-ready. Here's what I'd need to close them." Builds the gap-aware founder posture.

ELL deep moves

- **Three-statement template with bilingual labels.** P&L, cash flow, balance-sheet sketch in two languages.
- **Pitch script template** — present tense, simple sentences. Allow first practice in home language; final pitch in English.
- **Cognate-rich vocabulary.** Portafolio, runway, declaración de liderazgo.

IEP/504 deep moves

- **Pre-built financial pack spreadsheet.** Three statements pre-formatted; student enters data.
- **Defense in chunks.** A 30-min defense is a lot. Allow 6 × 5-min mini-segments with breaks for students who need.
- **Founder's leadership statement template.** 5 sections, 1 sentence each. Reduces blank-page paralysis.

The first-90-days checklist coaching

For students choosing launch — surface this checklist in the final two weeks and review with them privately, not as homework:

- **Register the entity.** Or don't. Sole prop is fine until liability/scale demands more.
- **Business bank account.** Don't mix personal and venture money. Even at small scale, this matters for taxes.
- **Sales tax nexus.** Where do you sell? Where do you owe? Look it up in your state.
- **Bookkeeping rhythm.** Sunday, 5 minutes, three numbers in a notebook (or app). Keep going.

- **Customer feedback loop.** Same loop they built at Grade 7. Run it.

ROUND 2 PATCH — Cash Never Says (Teacher Reference Card)

Cash never says: "Amazing!" / "Crushing it!" / "Boss up" / "Get that bag" / "Everyone can be rich" / "Easy money" / "Passive income" / "Financial freedom" / "Just believe" / "Side hustle" (use "side venture") / wealth-flexing language / anything implying wealth is mindset/hustle / anything implying low-income or unbanked families are at fault.

Cash always asks: "Which people, and how do you know?" / "Whats the evidence?" / "What would have to be true for you to be right/wrong?"

Teacher mirror: Replace "great job!" with "okay, thats specific — whats the evidence?"

Cashs three signature physical moves: (1) **Notebook Tilt**; (2) **Two-Finger Tap**; (3) **Slow Lean**.

ENDNOTES & STANDARDS

Citations and alignment

Grade 12 cites 3-6 standards across CCSS, Jump$tart, CEE, CASEL, and C3 frameworks. Detailed alignment lives in the master Standards Alignment Map.

1. **Jump$tart Coalition Personal Finance Standards (2021 ed.).** Spending and Saving; Credit and Debt; Employment and Income; Investing; Risk Management and Insurance; Financial Decision Making.
2. **Council for Economic Education (CEE).** Voluntary National Content Standards in Economics.
3. **CCSS-ELA, Grades 11-12.** W.11-12.1, W.11-12.4, SL.11-12.1, SL.11-12.4, RST.11-12.7.
4. **CCSS-Math.** N-Q.1-3 (Reasoning with Quantities), S-IC (Statistics & Inferences), F-IF (Functions), MP.4 (Modeling).
5. **CASEL Core Competencies.** Self-Awareness, Self-Management, Social Awareness, Relationship Skills, Responsible Decision-Making.
6. **C3 Framework for Social Studies State Standards.** Dimension 2 (Economics, Civics) at the high-school grade band.
7. **NGSS-ETS Engineering Practices.** ETS1 (Engineering Design) for the test-and-iterate spine of the year.
8. **Cash to Company Master Scope & Sequence.** 13 grades x 8 strands x 36 weeks; outcomes quoted verbatim from _master/00_Master_Scope_and_Sequence.md.
9. **Cash Mascot Style Guide.** 9-12 voice rules: multi-sentence arguments; vocabulary includes unit economics, runway, premortem, MVP; never flatters, never promises wealth.
10. **Sensitivity protocol.** No probing of family finances; financial scenarios framed as hypothetical for a sample household, business, or scenario.

One promise.

Cash to Company makes one promise: students who move t
program will be clearer thinkers about money and entrepren
matter what they end up doing for a living.

We do not promise wealth. We do not promise success. We pro

> **“Founder-defensible plans built on evidence, not enthusiasm.”**
>
> **- CASH, GRADE 12**

For educational use. This curriculum is informational and does not constitute financial, legal, or tax advice. Standards alignment cited per the Cash to Company Standards Alignment Map (Jump$tart, CEE, CCSS, C3, CASEL, NGSS-ETS).